

Multifunction Printers

A comparative test of inkjet and laser printers was conducted recently by International Consumer Research Testing (ICRT) where Consumer VOICE is an associate member. There were 22 models of printers from five brands: Brother, Canon, Dell, Epson and HP. The verdict and the buying guidelines follow



Brother MFC-5890CN printer

Nineteen printers in this test were inkjets. The ink arrangements were either individual tanks for each colour or two ink cartridges (one black and one multi-colour).

All the three colour lasers had separate toner cartridges.

Sixteen of the printers in this test were all-in-ones and they all could copy, scan and print. Eleven could also fax. When scanning, all the printers saved scans in several common image file types (jpg, tiff, pdf) and, with included optical character recognition (OCR) software, to common editable document types (doc, rtf, txt).

Let's see how all these printers fare in different respects.

Test outcomes

Connections. All the printers have USB connections. A unique feature in twelve of the inkjet printers is that they can print via PictBridge from a camera. In that case, the selection and printing of photos is controlled through the camera. Twelve of the inkjets have a built-in memory card reader. Selection and printing of photos is then done using the controls on the printer.

Paper feed. Most printers have an automatic paper feed that takes pages up to 21.6 cm wide. One of the wide-format printers takes paper up to 28.7 cm wide. The other five wide-format printers take paper up to 32.9 cm wide. Six of these printers can also print labels directly on CDs or DVDs.

Software. All of the printers can print from a computer running Windows 7, Vista, XP or a Mac running OS 10.5 or a higher version. They were all tested under Windows 7. In addition to drivers for Windows and Mac OS, most inkjet printers come bundled with a photo editing or organising software. Most all-in-one printers also come with OCR software.

If your PC needs only basic printing capability to a network-connected printer, you should be able to install just the printing driver software. If the installation mandates installing all components (faxing, photo management, Web printing, etc), which takes a long time and requires several user actions, it's a detriment to ease of use for networking.

Scenario-based evaluation. A scenario-based convenience evaluation was done for the test. This methodology prescribed twelve user scenarios covering all major functions of any regular, all-in-one or snapshot printer. Each scenario was carried out by at least two test technicians, and a rating for that scenario was given on a scale of 1-3.

Networking. Except for the lowest priced models, built-in networking is fairly standard in printers, allowing any computer inside (and sometimes, outside) the house to print directly without having to share through another PC. Most networked printers have a built-in webpage interface that can be accessed by any computer on the network to configure options and view status such as ink levels.

All-in-one models can also perform scanning through the network connection. Usually, the scan can be